

Job Satisfaction Through the Great Recession: Evidence from the General Social Survey, 2004-2014

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2026-05-28

Abstract

This paper examines whether the Great Recession altered the job satisfaction of employed US workers, both during the downturn and in its aftermath. Using six waves of the General Social Survey from 2004 to 2014, I compare mean job satisfaction across a pre-recession period (2004-2006), the recession period (2008-2010), and a post-recession period (2012-2014). I test three hypotheses, including a period-level recession effect on satisfaction, perceived job security as a possible mechanism, and an individual-level grateful worker effect among workers who began their current job during the recession. Descriptive results show only small movements in mean job satisfaction across the three periods, with means ranging from 3.33 to 3.37 on a four-point scale. OLS regression results indicate that the recession-period coefficient is positive across all specifications and reaches statistical significance in the specification with QWL controls that does not require years at current job, though the effect does not clear conventional thresholds in more restrictive subsamples. Perceived job security and general happiness emerge as the strongest individual-level predictors of satisfaction in the models that include them. A cohort analysis on the 2010 and 2014 subsamples finds no evidence that workers who began jobs during the recession reported higher satisfaction than those who began before or after.

Introduction

Recessions impose well-documented costs on workers who lose their jobs, but the effects on the workers who remain employed are less well understood. This paper asks how the Great Recession impacted the average US worker's view of job satisfaction. Examining job satisfaction among those who held jobs through the downturn is important because shifts in this measure can illuminate how labor market shocks ripple beyond unemployment, with potential consequences for turnover, productivity, and mental health. If satisfaction among the employed rises during a recession, that could reflect compositional changes in who remains in the workforce, a relative reframing of how workers value their jobs, or both. Each interpretation has distinct implications for how employers and policymakers think about retention, engagement, and worker well-being during economic downturns. This question matters because most existing work on the Great Recession either focuses on the unemployed or on broader subjective well-being, leaving job satisfaction among employed Americans comparatively underexamined.

I use the timeframe from 2008 to 2010 to classify the recession period. This is compared to clusters of years before and after the recession, from 2004 to 2006, and from 2012 to 2014.

My three core hypotheses are:

H1: Job satisfaction during the recession period (2008-2010) will be higher than in the pre-recession period, net of demographic controls.

H2: Perceived job security is positively associated with job satisfaction. To the extent that workers feel more secure during recessions, perceived security may help explain any observed recession-period differences in satisfaction.

H3: Workers who started during the recession will report higher satisfaction than those who started before or after.

Background

A longitudinal study on job satisfaction in the Netherlands during a recession (Pilipiec, Groot, and Pavlova 2020) serves as a basic guide for conducting this research, and provides context on past results. This study gathered longitudinal data following the 2007 financial crisis in the Netherlands, spanning six waves of a national panel, with later comparison to subsequent waves. The findings of this paper pointed to a decrease in job satisfaction before a recession, followed by an increase during the recession, although this was most likely due to shifts in the composition of workers with respect to job level. While I initially found some studies that have been performed in other countries, there does not seem to be a depth of literature for the United States.

A second paper, Bianchi (2013), reports three studies, analyzing the advantages of entering the workforce in a recession, which indicates that those who enter the workforce in a recession were more likely to be grateful for their jobs, holding greater job satisfaction. This offers some insight into the longer-term impacts of recession, and would be a point to examine if this is significant across the population following a recession. It should be noted that this is only an improvement in the mental perception of the job, as their broader career impacts are worse. Bianchi includes controls for personality traits and broad job characteristics like autonomy, but do not directly include workers' own perceptions of job security. That gap motivates my H2, which uses the GSS measure of perceived job security to test whether perceptions of security account for any recession-period shift in satisfaction.

A study by O'Connor (2017), similarly performed on the GSS data set, focused on understanding the impact of the Great Recession on subjective well-being, primarily observed through happiness. The primary difference between that study and what I outline above is that it focused on general happiness, whereas I aim to explore the specific effects on job satisfaction. I include happiness as a control rather than as an outcome here, on the view that general affective state is plausibly an input to how workers evaluate their jobs.

This data would refine our understanding of how workers reweight their existing jobs against a worse outside option, which speaks to the literature on reference-dependent preferences in labor markets and to applied questions about turnover and engagement during economic stress. If a recession-period satisfaction shift exists and is largely accounted for by perceived job security, the policy implication is closer to managing security perceptions in normal times than to anything about the recession itself.

Data and Methods

Data Source and Sample

My data source is the General Social Survey (GSS), from 2004 to 2014. This timeframe gives me an understanding of the years before the recession, the impact of the recession while in its midst,

and the long-running effects after the recession. While the Great Recession is typically considered to have ended by June of 2009, I will extend it to 2010 to include additional data due to the biennial nature of the GSS survey. I consider this an acceptable shift, given the ongoing job losses in 2010, indicating the continued impacts of the recession on the larger economy. My inclusion criteria are all GSS years between and including 2004 through 2014, and excluded all people not currently employed, which included the categories of “Unemployed, laid off, looking for work”, “Retired”, “In school”, “Keeping house”, and “Other” for the *wrkstat* variable. My analytic sample size is 8,176 entries after these exclusions. My unit of analysis is individuals in the United States.

Key Measures

The independent variable is the time period, comparing the pre-recession years of 2004 to 2006, the recession years of 2008 to 2010, and the post-recession years of 2012 to 2014. These years of data are broken into categories, for pre-recession, recession, and post-recession. The dependent variable is *satjob*, meant to measure the job satisfaction of the employed population of the United States. This is measured as “Very satisfied”, “Moderately satisfied”, “A little dissatisfied”, and “Very dissatisfied”. I will be reassigning these variables using a four-point scale from 1 to 4, going from very dissatisfied to very satisfied, which is detailed after explaining the QWL module. My central control covariates include age, sex, race, education, and income. Education is grouped into four categories: less than high school, high school, some college, and a bachelor's degree or higher. Income is measured as real income in constant dollars, rescaled to units of \$10,000 for clarity of interpretation in the regression models. Race is treated as a binary, being recoded to 1 being white, 2 being nonwhite.

In addition to these standard demographic controls, I include a set of workplace and psychosocial variables that come from the QWL module fielded as part of the GSS. The QWL controls I include are: perceived job security (*joblose*, with higher values indicating respondents feel less likely to lose their job in the next year), perceived availability of another job (*jobfind*), general happiness (*happy*), years at current job (*yearsjob*), hours worked last week (*hrs1*), number of other earners in the household (*earnrs*), being a supervisor (*wksup*), having a supervisor (*wksub*), part-time versus full-time status (*partfull*), and family income at age 16 (*incom16*). The QWL module was fielded in full in 2002, 2006, 2010, and 2014, but several of these workplace and psychosocial measures also appear in non-QWL waves through the GSS's split-ballot rotation. Within my 2004-2014 window, this means Model 2's controls are available for observations across all six survey years, though the per-year sample is substantially larger in the dedicated QWL waves (2006, 2010, 2014) than in the intervening years. I use complete-case analysis on these variables rather than imputation. I recoded *satjob* and *happy* so that higher values indicate greater satisfaction and greater happiness by setting *satjob* to 5-*satjob* and *happy* to 4-*happy*. For *satjob*, this shifts the original 1-4 scale (1 = very satisfied, 4 = very dissatisfied) so that 1 = very dissatisfied and 4 = very satisfied. For *happy*, the reassigned variable runs 1 = not too happy, 2 = pretty happy, 3 = very happy.

The cohort variable used in Model 4 is constructed from *yearsjob* (years at current job) and the survey year. A respondent's job start year is calculated as the survey year minus *yearsjob*. Respondents are then classified into three start cohorts: pre-recession starters who began their current jobs before 2008, recession starters who began their current jobs between 2008 and 2010 inclusive, and post-recession starters who began their jobs after 2010. For example, a 2014 respondent reporting four years at their current job is coded as a recession starter (start year =

2010), while a 2014 respondent reporting two years at the job is coded as a post-recession starter (start year = 2012). The reference category in Model 4 is pre-recession starters.

The GSS contains industry and occupation codes (indus10, indus80, occ10, occ80), but the coding schemes change across the 2004-2014 window in ways that complicate harmonization. Industry is therefore not included as a control in the present analysis, although the Netherlands study by Pilipiec et al. does control for industry. I treat this as a meaningful limitation rather than a denial that the data exist.

Missing Data and Analytic Considerations

One aspect to note is that this study only examines those who remained employed through the recession, which may further impact one's perception of job satisfaction. Workers with higher baseline satisfaction may also be more likely to retain their jobs, so the sample is selected in ways that could push aggregate satisfaction upward over time, even in the absence of any recession effect. There is no missing data on satjob, because the GSS codes non-employed respondents as inapplicable, and these cases are already removed by the workstat exclusion. My exclusions already remove refusals and don't know responses. Greater missingness is observed on real income, family income, and age, with 1,343, 705, and 21 cases lost, respectively. I use a complete-case analysis, dropping cases with missing values on any analytic variable. After this restriction, the period-only model (Model 1) uses 7,455 observations.

Model 2 uses 4,164 observations spanning all six survey years, restricted to respondents with non-missing values on the workplace and psychosocial controls. The 2006, 2010, and 2014 waves contribute the bulk of these observations (991, 687, and 901, respectively), with smaller contributions from 2004 (250), 2008 (687), and 2012 (649). Model 3 adds years at current job and further reduces the sample to 2,348 observations. Model 4 is restricted to 2010 and 2014 in order to test the cohort hypothesis, since respondents in 2006 could not have started their current job during or after the recession by definition. The cohort model uses 1,417 observations.

Analytic Strategy

I begin with descriptive comparisons of mean job satisfaction across the three periods, followed by four OLS regressions of job satisfaction. Models 1–3 use the pre-recession period as the reference category. Model 1 uses the full 2004-2014 sample and includes period dummies along with standard demographic controls (age, sex, education group, real income) to provide a broader view of the period. Model 2 introduces the QWL workplace and psychosocial controls on the larger all-years sample, omitting years at current job to retain observations that would otherwise drop out due to missingness on that variable. Model 3 then further restricts by adding years at the current job to the specification. Model 4 restricts further to 2010 and 2014, drops the period dummies, and adds an indicator for whether the respondent started their current job during or after the recession (using yearsjob to construct start-year cohorts), along with a year fixed effect. All models report HC3 robust standard errors.

Results

Descriptive Patterns

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics by Time Period

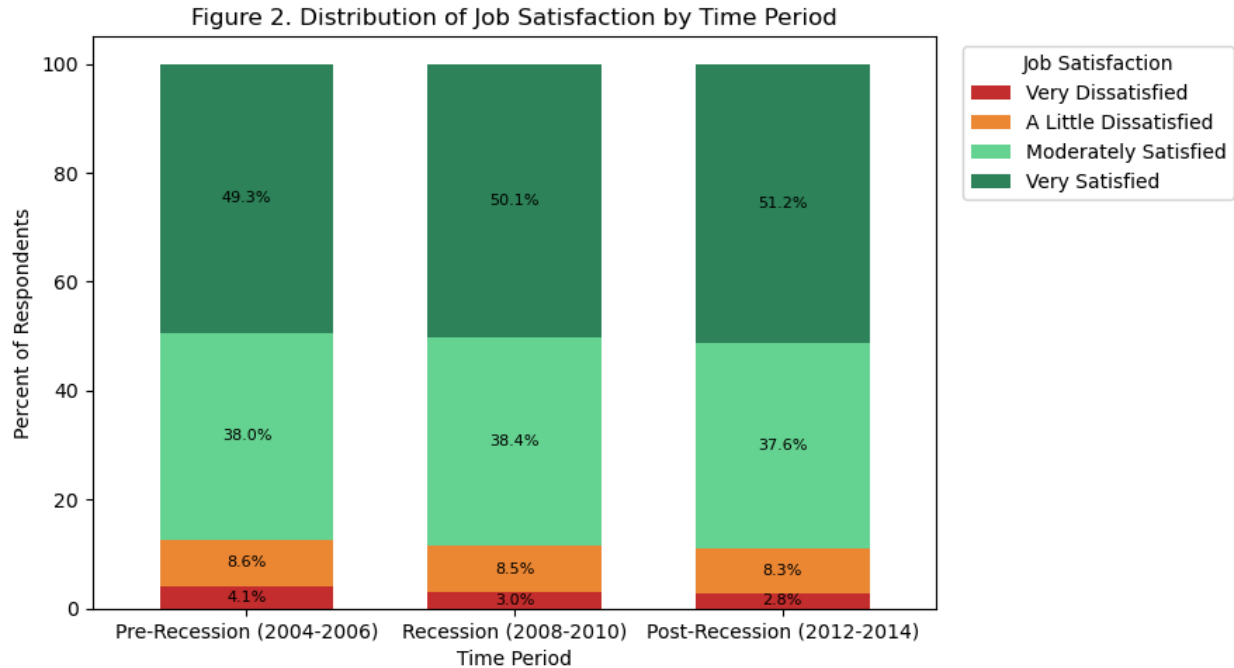
	Pre-Recession (2004-2006)	Recession (2008-2010)	Post-Recession (2012-2014)
Mean Age	41.95	43.24	43.65
Female (%)	50.2	50.6	50.3
White (%)	74.5	76.6	74.2
Mean Years of Education	13.93	13.90	14.02
Mean Real Income (\$)	\$25,671	\$29,105	\$27,074
Mean Job Satisfaction	3.325	3.356	3.373
N	3,047	2,427	2,702

Note: N = 8,176. Source: GSS 2004-2014, currently employed respondents only.

Table 1 reports descriptive statistics by time period for the analytic sample of 8,176 employed respondents. The three subsamples are broadly similar on demographic characteristics, with mean age increasing slightly from 41.95 in the pre-recession period to 43.65 in the post-recession period, and the share of women and white respondents remaining nearly flat across periods. Mean years of education are also stable, ranging from 13.90 to 14.02 years. Mean real income is highest during the recession period, at \$29,105, compared to \$25,671 pre-recession and \$27,074 post-recession, which may reflect the compositional shift in employment that Pilipiec et al. describe, as lower-income workers were disproportionately likely to lose their jobs during the downturn. Mean job satisfaction is highest in the post-recession period (3.373), followed by the recession period (3.356), and lowest in the pre-recession period (3.325).



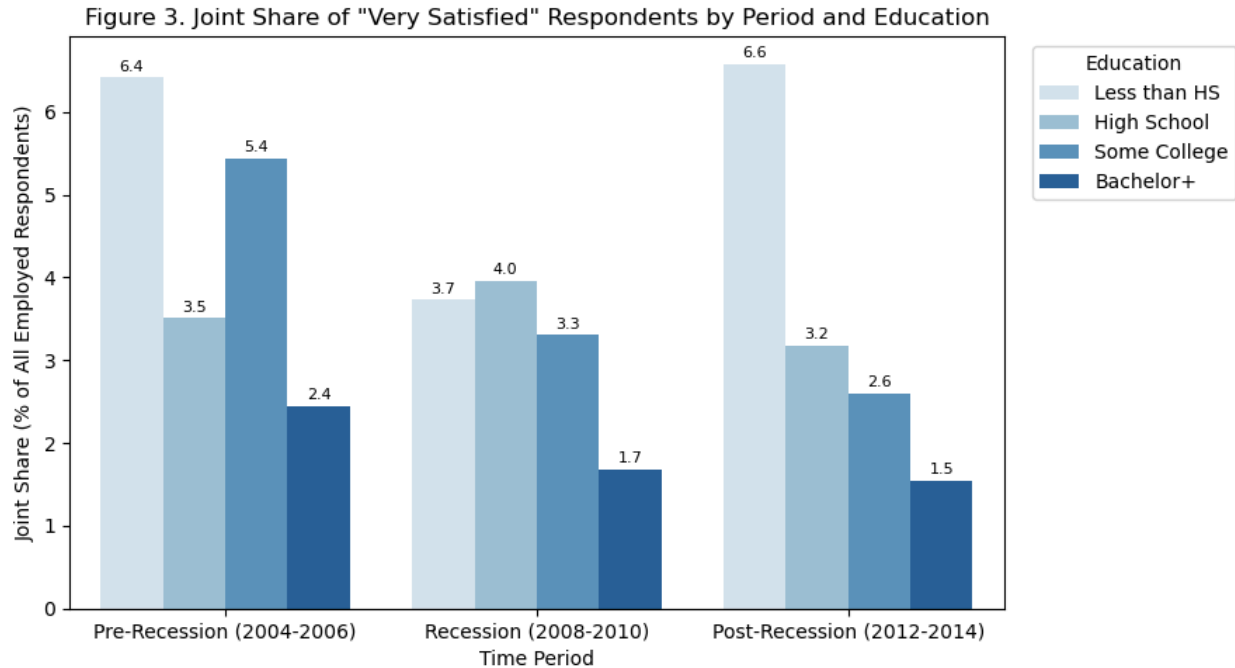
Figure 1 plots mean job satisfaction by individual survey year. The annual means fluctuate within a narrow band between 3.3 and 3.4 throughout the observation period. There was a small upward bump in 2008, followed by a return to roughly the pre-recession level in 2010, after which there is a slight drift upward in 2012 and 2014. The 95 percent confidence intervals around these point estimates overlap considerably across most years, which suggests that the period-to-period differences in mean job satisfaction are modest in magnitude. The visual pattern is broadly consistent with the descriptive trend in Table 1, although it does not provide strong support for a sharp recession-driven shift.



Note: N = 8,176 (Pre = 3,047, Recession = 2,427, Post = 2,702). Source: GSS 2004-2014.

Figure 2 displays the full distribution of job satisfaction by time period. The most striking pattern is the small but consistent decline in the share of respondents reporting that they are very dissatisfied with their jobs, falling from 4.1 percent pre-recession to 3.0 percent during the recession and 2.8 percent post-recession. The share reporting that they are very satisfied rises modestly from 49.3 percent to 50.1 percent to 51.2 percent across the three periods. The two middle categories remain roughly constant. This suggests that whatever movement is occurring is concentrated at the tails of the distribution, particularly in the reduction of strong dissatisfaction. One reading of this pattern is that workers most likely to express strong dissatisfaction are also those most likely to exit the employed sample during a downturn.

Figure 3 plots the joint share of respondents who are both "very satisfied" and in each education group, expressed as a percentage of all employed respondents in the period. The most visible movement is among workers with less than a high school education, whose joint share falls from 6.4 percent pre-recession to 3.7 percent during the recession before recovering to 6.6 percent post-recession. The joint share combines the within-group satisfaction rate with the share of the employed sample in that education group, so a drop can come either from low-education workers becoming less satisfied or from fewer low-education workers being employed in the first place. The recession-period dip and subsequent recovery are most readily read as the latter, with low-education workers disproportionately likely to exit the employed sample during the downturn. This is consistent with the compositional reading of the income pattern in Table 1. The joint shares for the more educated groups drift downward across periods, but the same caveat applies: the figure on its own cannot distinguish within-group satisfaction changes from shifts in the education composition of the employed sample.



Note: N = 8,167. Source: GSS 2004-2014.

Regression Results

Table 2 presents four OLS regressions of job satisfaction with the pre-recession period serving as the reference category in Models 1, 2, and 3. Model 1 estimates the period effects on the full 2004-2014 sample with standard demographic controls. The recession coefficient is 0.038 (SE = 0.022), and the post-recession coefficient is 0.041 (SE = 0.021). Both are positive and consistent in direction with H1, but neither reaches the 0.05 significance threshold. Education and age are both significant predictors of satisfaction in this specification, with bachelor's degree holders reporting satisfaction 0.143 points higher than those with less than a high school education, and a \$10,000 increase in real income associated with a 0.020 point increase in satisfaction. The R-squared of 0.034 indicates that period and demographics together account for a small share of the variation in individual job satisfaction.

Table 2. OLS Regressions of Job Satisfaction

	Model 1 (Full Sample)	Model 2 (QWL Controls)	Model 3 (QWL Subsample)	Model 4 (2010+2014)
Intercept	2.882*** (0.055)	1.875*** (0.150)	1.714*** (0.209)	1.652*** (0.268)
Recession (2008-2010)	0.038 (0.022)	0.088** (0.029)	0.068 (0.038)	
Post-Recession (2012-2014)	0.041 (0.021)	0.059* (0.029)	0.031 (0.037)	
Started job during recession				-0.031 (0.060)
Started job post-recession				0.042 (0.068)
Year = 2014				-0.058 (0.046)
Perceived job security		0.115*** (0.017)	0.117*** (0.024)	0.109*** (0.029)
Could find another job		-0.035* (0.015)	-0.025 (0.021)	-0.015 (0.027)
General happiness		0.279*** (0.021)	0.277*** (0.028)	0.282*** (0.034)
Years at current job			-0.002 (0.002)	0.001 (0.003)
Hours worked last week		0.002** (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.003 (0.002)
Other earners in household		-0.026 (0.018)	-0.049* (0.025)	-0.038 (0.031)
Is a supervisor		-0.085*** (0.024)	-0.071* (0.033)	-0.051 (0.041)
Has supervisor		0.111*** (0.030)	0.116** (0.040)	0.055 (0.054)
Part-time vs full-time		-0.066 (0.037)	-0.068 (0.050)	-0.037 (0.060)
Family income at age 16		0.031* (0.013)	0.065*** (0.017)	0.063** (0.021)
High School	0.100** (0.034)	0.087 (0.045)	0.132* (0.066)	0.061 (0.080)
Some College	0.077* (0.034)	0.010 (0.045)	0.050 (0.066)	-0.030 (0.078)
Bachelor+ degree	0.143*** (0.034)	0.031 (0.046)	0.089 (0.067)	0.094 (0.080)
Age	0.006*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.008*** (0.001)	0.010*** (0.002)
Race	-0.025 (0.013)	0.001 (0.017)	-0.009 (0.024)	-0.009 (0.032)
Female	0.024 (0.018)	0.046 (0.024)	0.045 (0.032)	0.060 (0.041)
Real income (per \$10k)	0.020*** (0.003)	0.008* (0.003)	0.010 (0.005)	0.009 (0.007)
N	7,455	4,164	2,348	1,417
R-squared	0.034	0.117	0.124	0.146
Adj. R-squared	0.032	0.113	0.117	0.134

Note: HC3 robust standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Source: GSS 2004-2014, currently employed respondents only.

Model 2 introduces the QWL workplace and psychosocial controls while retaining a larger analytic sample than Model 3, and omits years at current job to preserve observations that would otherwise be dropped due to the heavy missingness on that variable. This intermediate specification is included to separate the effect of adding the new controls from the effect of the further sample restriction that the cohort analysis ultimately requires. The model uses 4,164 observations drawn from all six survey years, retaining respondents with non-missing values on the workplace and psychosocial controls. Because Model 2 covers the same year span as Model 1, though the QWL-complete subsample is not a random subset, the change in the recession coefficient from Model 1 to Model 2 reflects the addition of controls rather than a change in which periods are represented in the sample. The recession-period coefficient is 0.088 (SE = 0.029), and the post-recession coefficient is 0.059 (SE = 0.029), both statistically significant at the 0.01 and 0.05 levels, respectively. This is the only specification in which the period reaches conventional significance, which suggests that the inconclusive result in Model 3 reflects a loss of precision in the smaller subsample rather than the additional control for years at current job attenuating the recession pattern itself. Perceived job security (0.115, $p < 0.001$) and general

happiness (0.279, $p < 0.001$) again emerge as the dominant individual-level predictors, alongside being a supervisor (-0.085, $p < 0.001$) and having a supervisor (0.111, $p < 0.001$). Hours worked last week, family income at age 16, and real income are also significant. The education coefficients shrink substantially relative to Model 1 and largely lose significance, suggesting that the education gradient observed in the full-sample model is being absorbed by the psychosocial and household variables now in the specification. The R-squared rises to 0.117, more than triple the value in Model 1.

Model 3 is restricted to the QWL subsample of 2006, 2010, and 2014 and years at current job. The recession-period coefficient falls to 0.068. The post-recession coefficient drops to 0.031 and is also not significant. Adding years at current job, therefore does not eliminate the recession-period pattern, but the increased standard errors in this smaller sample mean that the period contrast remains statistically inconclusive. The dominant predictors in Model 3 remain perceived job security (0.117, $p < 0.001$) and general happiness (0.277, $p < 0.001$). The R-squared increases slightly to 0.124.

Model 4 is restricted to the 2010 and 2014 subsamples to test the individual-level cohort hypothesis. Neither of the cohort dummies approaches significance. Workers who started their current job during the recession do not differ meaningfully in satisfaction from those who started before (-0.031, SE = 0.060), and post-recession starters do not either (0.040, SE = 0.068). The year-2014 dummy is also not significant. Perceived job security and general happiness continue to be the strongest predictors. The cohort model explains a slightly larger share of variation than the QWL period model, with an R-squared of 0.146, primarily through age and the psychosocial controls rather than the cohort indicators themselves.

Evaluation of Hypotheses

Across the three models in which it appears, the recession-period coefficient is positive in every specification, ranging from 0.038 in Model 1 to 0.088 in Model 2. The direction is consistent with H1, and the fact that the estimate grows rather than shrinks as workplace and psychosocial controls are added suggests that the period contrast is real rather than an artifact of omitted variable bias. Model 2 provides the clearest support for H1, with a recession-period coefficient of 0.088 ($p < 0.01$) and a post-recession coefficient of 0.059 ($p < 0.05$). Because Model 2 covers the same year span as Model 1, though the QWL-complete subsample is not a random subset, the increase in the recession coefficient from Model 1 to Model 2 reflects adjustment for workplace and psychosocial confounders rather than a change in which periods enter the sample, which is the opposite of what one would expect if the period effect were an artifact of omitted confounding. The further loss of significance in Model 3 reflects a precision cost from the smaller subsample once yearsjob is added, rather than a substantive change in the recession-period estimate, which remains positive in magnitude. It should further be noted that job satisfaction is strictly increasing across the periods, which could be indicative of a secular trend. Taken together, the evidence supports H1, but would benefit from further testing to confirm.

H2 receives clear support in its main-effect form. Perceived job security is among the strongest individual-level predictors of job satisfaction in every model that includes it, with coefficients of 0.115, 0.117, and 0.109 (all $p < 0.001$) across Models 2 through 4. The original mediation framing of H2, however, does not hold cleanly: adding job security and the other QWL controls

does not attenuate the recession-period coefficient as a simple mediation story would predict, and the coefficient actually grows in Models 2 and 3 relative to Model 1. The pattern is more consistent with job security being a strong predictor of satisfaction in its own right than with job security explaining away the period effect. This still contributes a piece that the existing literature largely assumes rather than tests, in line with the gap identified relative to Bianchi (2013) and Pilipiec et al. (2020). To directly test whether the job-security/satisfaction association strengthens during recessions, I re-estimated Model 2 with a Recession $\times$ Job Security interaction. The interaction coefficient is 0.019 (SE = 0.041, $p = 0.64$) for the recession period and 0.017 (SE = 0.042, $p = 0.68$) for the post-recession period. The slope of satisfaction on job security is statistically indistinguishable across periods, at roughly 0.10 per unit. Perceived job security is a strong predictor of job satisfaction, but the strength of that relationship does not appear to vary with the macroeconomic context.

H3 is not supported. Workers who started their current job during the recession do not report higher satisfaction than those who started before the recession, and post-recession starters do not differ either. The individual-level grateful worker pattern described by Bianchi does not replicate in this GSS sample within the 2010 and 2014 cohort window. The standard errors are large enough that I cannot rule out a small effect, but the point estimate for during-recession starters is actually slightly negative, which is the wrong direction for the pattern described by Bianchi.

Conclusions

This paper examined whether the Great Recession was associated with changes in job satisfaction among employed US workers between 2004 and 2014. Mean job satisfaction moved upward across the three periods by 0.04 to 0.09 points on a four-point scale. The period coefficients reach conventional significance only in Model 2, which adds QWL controls while retaining respondents from all six survey years. The most consistent finding is not the period contrast but the mechanism variable: perceived job security and general happiness are strong individual-level predictors of satisfaction in every specification that includes them, with effect sizes much larger than those of the period dummies. The cohort analysis on the 2010 and 2014 samples finds no evidence that workers who began jobs during the recession report higher satisfaction than those who began before or after, a meaningful null relative to Bianchi (2013), though the smaller cohort sample limits what can be inferred.

This study has flaws. The analysis is restricted to employed respondents, so workers who lost their jobs during the recession are not in the sample. If those workers held systematically lower job satisfaction before being separated from their jobs, the small positive shifts I observe could partly reflect this composition effect rather than a change in attitudes among continuously employed workers. The GSS's biennial structure means I cannot pin down the exact timing of any within-period changes, and the absence of harmonized industry controls limits my ability to address the compositional shifts identified in the Netherlands study. The QWL-restricted sample used in Models 2, 3, and 4 also reduces precision, and the cross-sectional structure means the mechanism claims about job security are associational rather than causal.

Despite these limitations, the consistency of the small positive shifts in the recession coefficient across models and the strength of perceived job security as a predictor together suggest that the recession was not associated with a sharp decline in job satisfaction among those who remained employed. Whether the small positive shifts reflect survivorship, a grateful worker effect

operating at an aggregate level that is too small for the individual cohort analysis to detect, or a broader secular trend remains an open question that would benefit from longitudinal data.

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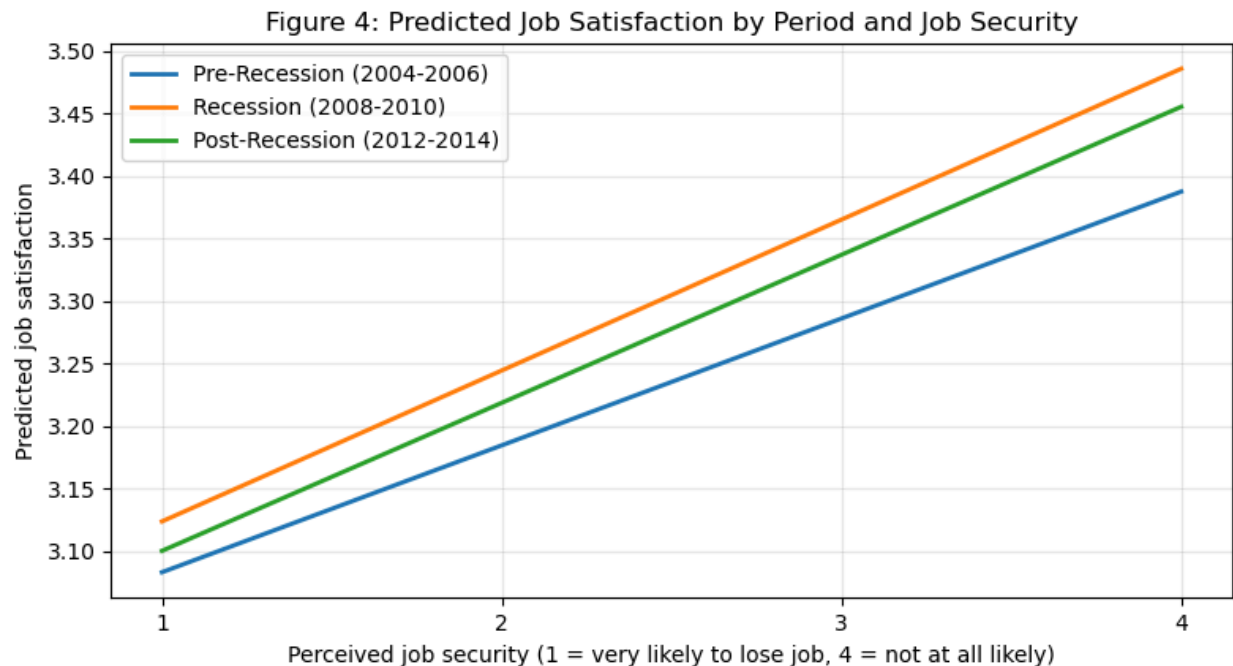
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Appendix



Note: The near-parallel slopes across the three lines visualize the null moderation result reported in the H2 section: the strength of the job security/satisfaction relationship does not vary meaningfully by period.